

Lab: Pragmatism and the Primacy of Practice

Learning Goal: Apply pragmatist philosophy to Active Inference's account of action.

Part 1: Pragmatist Mapping

Exercise: Complete the mapping and evaluate each:

Pragmatist Concept	Active Inference Analog	Evaluation
Peirce: Doubt triggers inquiry	Prediction error triggers inference	
James: Truth = what works	Model evidence = predictive success	
Dewey: Cognition as instrument	Generative model as survival tool	
Dewey: Habit as organized activity	Policy prior	
Peirce: Abduction	Bayesian model selection	

Which mapping is strongest? Which is most misleading? (300 words)

Write your response here

Part 2: Affordance Analysis

Learning Goal: Apply affordance theory through Active Inference formalization.

Exercise: Analyze the affordances of a simple object (e.g., a chair) for different agents:

Agent	Affordance of a Chair	EFE Analysis (why this affordance?)
Human adult	Sitting (reduces physical fatigue PE)	
Toddler	Climbing (reduces curiosity PE)	
Cat	Platform (reduces surveillance PE)	
Robot vacuum	Obstacle (increases navigation PE)	

How does the affordance depend on the agent's generative model?

Write your response here

Part 3: Skill Acquisition Diary

Learning Goal: Apply Dreyfus's expertise model through Active Inference.

Exercise: Choose a skill you've developed (playing an instrument, coding, cooking, a sport). Map your progression through Dreyfus's five stages:

Stage	Your Experience	Generative Model Status	Policy Prior Status
Novice		Thin, rule-based	Uniform
Adv. Beginner		Context-sensitive	Slightly shaped
Competent		Goal-organized	Moderately shaped
Proficient		Holistic pattern recognition	Strongly shaped
Expert		Intuitive, low PE	Habitual

Write your response here

Part 4: Epistemic Actions in Daily Life

Exercise: Identify three "epistemic actions" from your daily life — actions taken primarily to reduce uncertainty rather than achieve a goal. Analyze each through the EFE framework (what is the epistemic value?).

Write your response here

Part 5: Reflection

In 250 words, reflect: How does the pragmatist insight "truth is what works" change your understanding of what generative models *do*? Does this make the FEP more or less philosophically interesting?

Write your response here

Lab Summary

Part	Skill Practiced	Key Concept
1	Historical mapping	Pragmatism ↔ Active Inference
2	Applied analysis	Affordance formalization
3	Self-analysis	Expertise development
4	Daily observation	Epistemic actions
5	Philosophical reflection	Pragmatist truth